Charles Darwin



Born in Shropshire, UK, in 1809, Darwin was fascinated by natural history from a young age. While at Cambridge University, he became friendly with several influential naturalists, including John Stevens Henslow. As a result, Darwin was invited to join the HMS *Beagle* expedition around the world. Henslow helped Darwin catalog and publicize his finds.

Darwin's research brought him fame and recognition—the Royal Society's Royal Medal in 1853, nd fellowship of the Linnean Society in 1854. In 1859, his book *On the Origin of Species* sold out instantly. Despite continuing ill-health, Darwin fathered 10 children and never stopped studying and developing new theories. He died in 1882.

Key works

1839 *Zoology of the Voyage of HMS* Beagle

1859 *On the Origin of Species by Means of Natural Selection*

1868 *The Variation of Animals and Plants under Domestication*

1872 *The Expression of Emotions in Man and Animals*

Darwin's conclusions

On Darwin's return to England, the differing beaks of the small birds he had found on the Galápagos, usually called "finches" although they are not in the true finch family, set him thinking. He knew that a bird's beak is its key tool for feeding, so its length and shape offer clues to its diet. Later research